

MICHAEL HALL, PhD

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ACADEMIC POSITIONS:

Associate Professor, Department of English, Virginia Commonwealth University (VCU), 2023-Present (Affiliated Faculty, Department of African American Studies, VCU)

Assistant Professor, Department of English, Virginia Commonwealth University (VCU), 2015-2022

Postdoctoral Fellow in African American Literature, Department of English, VCU, 2014-2015

EDUCATION:

PhD, Emory University, Atlanta, GA, May 2014
Area: Interdisciplinary Studies in Culture and Society/American Studies

M.A., Emory University, Atlanta, GA, August 2011
Area: Interdisciplinary Studies in Culture and Society/American Studies

M.P.S., Cornell University, Ithaca, NY, May 2008
Area: Africana Studies; African American Studies and American Art

B.A. (Summa cum laude), Southeastern Louisiana University, Hammond, LA, May 2006
Major: English; Minor(s): Spanish, History

AREAS OF SPECIALIZATION:

20th-century and contemporary African American literature and culture
Narrative and visual culture
Travel and imagination
Cultural histories of travel
Race and recreation
Speculative fiction

PUBLICATIONS:

Books

[*Freedom Beyond Confinement: Travel and Imagination in African American Cultural History and Letters*](#). African American Literature Series (Clemson University Press 2022)

- *Freedom Beyond Confinement* examines the cultural history of African American travel and the lasting influence of travel on the imagination particularly of writers of literary fiction and nonfiction. Using the paradox of freedom and confinement to frame the ways travel represented both opportunity and restriction for African Americans, the book details the intimate connection between travel and imagination from post Reconstruction (ca. 1877) to the present. Analyzing a range of sources from the black press and periodicals to literary fiction and nonfiction, the book charts the development of critical representation of travel from the foundational press and periodicals which offered African Americans crucial information on travel precautions and possibilities (notably during the era of Jim Crow) to the woefully understudied literary fiction that would later provide some of the most compelling and lasting portrayals of the freedoms and constraints African Americans associated with travel. Travel experiences (often challenging and vexed) provided the raw data with which writers produced images and ideas meaningful as they learned to navigate, negotiate and even challenge racialized and gendered impediments to their mobility. In their writings African Americans worked to realize a vision and state of freedom informed by those often difficult experiences of mobility. In telling this story, the book centers literary fiction in studies of travel writing where fiction has largely remained absent.
- *Freedom Beyond Confinement* has been reviewed in [The Journal of Transport History](#) (2022), [MELUS: Journal of the Society for the Study of Multi-ethnic Literature of the United States](#) (2023), and [American Literary History](#) (2024).
- To hear me discussing the book see these interviews with [Liverpool University Press](#), [VCU News](#), Virginia Humanities [With Good Reason](#), and this [book talk](#) at VCU's Humanities Research Center.

Peer-Reviewed Journal Articles

"The Negro Traveller's Guide to a Jim Crow South: Negotiating Racialized Landscapes During a Dark Period in US Cultural History, 1936-1967," [Postcolonial Studies](#), Vol. 17, Iss. 3 (2015), 307-319. [Invited]

"Dramatizing the African American Experience of Travel in the Jim Crow South: The Negro Motorist Green Book in the African American Literary Imagination," [South Carolina Review](#), Vol. 46, No. 2 (2014), 80-94.

Peer-Reviewed Book Chapters

"Fact or Fiction?: (Re)Defining the Study of (African American and Black Atlantic) Travel Writing." *The Bloomsbury Handbook to Multiethnic US Travel Writing*. Ed. Gary Totten. London: Bloomsbury Forthcoming [Invited]

"How did I (We) Get Here?: Speculative Time Travel and the Contested Place of

Technology in Afrofuturistic Fictions.” [Introduction to Afrofuturism: A Mix Tape in Black Literature & Arts](#). Ed. DuEwa Frazier. New York: Routledge 2024. [Invited]

“Scenes of Black Masculinity and Wanderlust: Gendered Mobility and Film Diaspora in *Emperor Jones*.” [Motion Pictures: Travel Ideals in Film](#). Ed. Andrew McGregor and Emma Blackwood. Switzerland: Peter Lang Publishers, 2016, 151-165. [Invited]

“The Prominence of the Railroad in the African American Imagination: Mobile Men, Gendered Mobility and the Poetry of Sterling A. Brown.” [Travel and Imagination](#). Ed. Garth Lean, Russell Staiff and Emma Waterton. Farnham: Ashgate Publishing Co., 2014, 89-102.

Book Reviews

Hall, Michael Ra-shon, rev. of James B. Haile, III’s *The Dark Delight of Being Strange: Black Stories of Freedom* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2024), [American Literary History](#), Volume 38, Issue 3, July 2026, 1-3. [Invited]

Hall, Michael Ra-shon, rev. of Miriam Thaggert’s *Riding Jane Crow: African American Women on the American Railroad* (Urbana: University of Illinois Press, 2022), [American Literary History](#), Volume 35, Issue 3, Fall 2023, 1452–1454. [Invited]

Hall, Michael Ra-shon, rev. of William Merrill Decker’s *Geographies of Flight: Phyllis Wheatley to Octavia Butler* (Evanston: Northwestern University Press, 2020), [MELUS: Society for the Study of the Multi-Ethnic Literature of the United States](#), Volume 47, Issue 2, Summer 2022, 222–224. [Invited]

Hall, Michael Ra-shon, rev. of Elizabeth Stordeur Pryor’s *Colored Travelers: Mobility and the Fight for Citizenship before the Civil War* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 2016), [Journal of Transport History](#), Volume 39 (1), Summer 2018 [Invited]

Hall, Michael Ra-shon, rev. of Sarah Jane Cervenak’s *Wandering: Philosophical Performances of Racial and Sexual Freedom* (Durham: Duke University Press, 2014), [Transfers: Interdisciplinary Journal of Mobility Studies](#), Volume 6(1), Spring 2016 [Invited]

Finding Aids

Co-authored with Sarah Quigley, Danica Tisdale, Brenda Tindal, Rebecca Sherman, Chanel Craft, Gianluca De Fazio and Ryan Taylor, “Finding Aid for the Southern Christian Leadership Conference Records,” Manuscript, Archives, & Rare Book Library, Robert W. Woodruff Library, Emory University, 2012. Permanent link: <http://pid.emory.edu/ark:/25593/90wfs>

Digital Scholarship

Taylor, Ryan and Michael R. Hall. “The SCLC National Conventions: A Photographic Retrospective,” Manuscript, Archives and Rare Book Library Blog, Robert W. Woodruff

Library, Emory University, October 27, 2011:

<https://scholarblogs.emory.edu/woodruff/uncategorized/the-sclc-national-conventions-a-photographic-retrospective>

Single-Authored Blogs for Manuscript, Archives, and Rare Book Library (MARBL),
Robert W. Woodruff Library, Emory University:

“Unearthing the "V" in the A/V Material of the SCLC Collection,” July 12, 2011

<https://scholarblogs.emory.edu/woodruff/uncategorized/unearthing-the-v-in-the-av-material-of-the-sclc-collection>

“Student Involvement in the Post Civil Rights Era,” June 13, 2011:

<https://scholarblogs.emory.edu/woodruff/uncategorized/student-involvement-in-the-post-civil-rights-era>

“Civil Rights Activism and the Crisis in Healthcare,” January 21, 2011:

<https://scholarblogs.emory.edu/woodruff/uncategorized/civil-rights-activism-and-the-crisis-in-healthcare>

“New Insights into the Early Political and Philosophical Thought of Jesse L. Jackson,”
January 11, 2010:

<https://scholarblogs.emory.edu/marbl/2010/11/01/new-insights-into-the-early-political-and-philosophical-thought-of-jesse-l-jackson/>

RESEARCH IN PROGRESS:

“Between Leisure and Servitude: Postcards and the Early Cultural History of African American Travel, 1850-1945” (book)

HONORS AND AWARDS:

2025

Stanley Pargellis Fellow, Newberry Library, Chicago, IL (Sept. 2025-May 2026)

Conference Travel Grant for travel to New Orleans, LA, Humanities Research Center,
VCU

2024

NEH Summer Stipend Grant

Conference Travel Grant for travel to Chicago, IL, Humanities Research Center,
VCU

2023

5x5 Collaborative Grant, Humanities Research Center, VCU

Research Travel Grant for travel to Chicago, IL, Humanities Research Center, VCU

Conference Travel Grant for travel to San Antonio, TX, Humanities Research Center,
VCU

2022

Fellow, Humanities Research Center, VCU, Spring

2021

Conference Travel Grant for travel to Washington, DC, Humanities Research Center,
VCU

Seed Grant, College of Humanities and Sciences, VCU

2018

Conference Travel Grant for travel to Washington, DC, Humanities Research Center,
VCU

2017

Conference Travel Grant for travel to Indianapolis, IN, Humanities Research Center,
VCU

2016

Conference Travel Grant for travel to San Diego, CA, Humanities Research Center, VCU

INVITED TALKS:

[“Community Conversation: The Eggleston Family Legacy and *The Green Book*”](#), Virginia Museum of Fine Arts (VMFA) with Melody Short, Director of Operations and Marketing, Akwaaba Bed & Breakfast Inns, January 26, 2020

TALKS AT VCU:

“Travel and African American Imagination: A Conversation between Dr. Michael Ra-shon Hall and Dr. Kimberly Nichele Brown,” Meet VCU Authors, HRC, VCU, February 6, 2023.

“Detours Through the Past: Traversing Paradigms in Octavia Butler’s *Kindred*,” Faculty Forum, Department of English, VCU, April 2022

“Variations on a Paradoxical Theme: Gendered Mobility, Modern Travel and Imagination in Hurston’s Early Novels,” Faculty Forum, Department of English, VCU, March 2018

CONFERENCES:

Individual Presentations

“Between Leisure and Servitude: Postcards and the Rise of a (Racialized) Leisure Industry in the US,” Popular Culture Association National Conference, New Orleans, LA, April 2025.

“Between History and Memory: Periodical Covers, Postcards, and the Black Press,” Modern Language Association National Convention, New Orleans, LA, January 2025.

“Picturing Leisure and Hospitality: Postcards, Periodical Covers, and the Early Emergence of a (Racialized) Tourist Industry in the US,” Popular Culture Association National Conference, Chicago, IL, March 2024

“Black (In/Ex)clusion: Race, Recreation, and the Visual Rhetoric of Postcards in Ohio (ca. 1900-1940),” Popular Culture Association National Conference, San Antonio, TX April 2023.

“Freedom and Its Discontents: Langston Hughes’s “Freedom Train” and Travel in the Black Imaginary,” Popular Culture Association National Conference, Virtual, April 2022.

“Freedom and Its Discontents: Langston Hughes’s “Freedom Train” and Travel in the Black Imaginary,” Modern Language Association National Convention, Washington, DC, January 2022.

“The See-Saw of Race’: Langston Hughes, Travel Report, and a Modern Problematic Mirrored in the Black Press,” Popular Culture Association National Conference, Virtual, June, 2021

“Traversing Paradigms: Travel as Trope in Octavia Butler’s *Kindred*,” Popular Culture Association National Conference, Washington, DC, April, 2019

“Searching for a Place to Belong: Inverted Tourism and Disembodied Mobility in Nella Larsen’s *Quicksand*,” Popular Culture Association National Conference, Indianapolis, IN, March, 2018

“Variations on a Paradoxical Theme: Gendered Mobility, Modern Travel and Imagination in Hurston’s Early Travels and Creative Works,” Popular Culture Association National Conference, San Diego, CA, April, 2017

“The Negro Traveler's Guide to a Jim Crow South: Negotiating Racialized Landscapes During a Dark Period in U.S. Cultural History, 1936-1967,” Popular Culture Association National Conference, Seattle, WA, March 21-25, 2016

“Scenes of Black Masculinity and Wanderlust: Travel, Gendered Mobility and Film Diaspora in the *Emperor Jones*.” 2014 Popular Culture Association/American Culture Association National Conference, Chicago, IL, April 2014.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE:

Assistant to the Associate Director, Center for Faculty Development and Excellence, Emory University, June 2013-June 2014

- Working under the direction of the Associate Director, I helped to organize faculty development programs, workshops and resources to assist faculty across all colleges at Emory with improving their research profiles and pedagogy. Programs I helped to organize included Academic Learning Communities for faculty to improve pedagogy in teaching science and writing across the college, author development to heighten research profiles for faculty across the college and professional development workshops for graduate instructors among other programs. Additionally, I aided the Associate Director with program assessment and review as part of a self-study and external review to improve the quality of the services the Center offers.

Curatorial Associate, “And the Struggle Continues: The Southern Christian Leadership Conference’s Fight for Social Change,” Co-curated with Dr. Carol Anderson and Sarah Quigley, Manuscript, Archives and Rare Book Library (MARBL), Emory University, May 2012-December 2013. Exhibition on view in the Schatten Gallery of Emory’s Robert W. Woodruff Library from February 21 to December 1, 2013.

- Collaborating with archivist Sarah Quigley and Dr. Carol Anderson, Charles Howard Candler Professor of African American Studies, I organized an exhibit based on the Southern Christian Leadership Conference papers housed at Emory. Featuring selected items from the collection, the exhibit presented SCLC’s continued relevancy and social activism in the decades following Martin Luther King, Jr.’s assassination in 1968 up until the present. Using audiovisual technologies and presenting images, printed material and material artifacts hardly seen by the public, “And the Struggle Continues” is the first major exhibit showcasing SCLC. The exhibit opening was covered by the [New York Times](#), [Atlanta Journal Constitution](#), [Cable News Network](#) (CNN) and National Public Radio (NPR) in addition to a following feature in [Emory Magazine](#). Most important for me is the [NPR](#) article with audio following interviews of me and Civil Rights icon Dorothy Cotton by NPR national correspondent Kathy Lohr.

Manuscript Collection Processor, Papers of the Southern Christian Leadership Conference, MARBL, Emory University, Atlanta, GA, July 2009-April 2012.

- Supported by a grant from the Council on Library and Information Resources, I collaborated with project archivist Sarah Quigley and other graduate students to process the papers of the Southern Christian Leadership Conference (SCLC). I also periodically produced academic blog entries to update the public about significant findings during the processing of the collection. The collection documents the activities of the civil rights organization from 1968-2007, offers unprecedented accessibility to primary sources on SCLC, and opened to the public for research May 1, 2012 (See link to finding aid above).

Research Assistant, Rudolph P. Byrd, *The World Has Changed: Conversations With Alice Walker* (2010), Ed. Rudolph P. Byrd, Emory University, Atlanta, GA, January-May 2009.

- As research assistant for the first volume of Alice Walker's interviews *The World Has Changed* (2010) edited by my late advisor Dr. Rudolph P. Byrd, I gathered interviews and relevant copyright information. I worked independently, while reporting weekly progress to Dr. Byrd, and, as a result, I developed a more efficient ability to search academic databases and popular sources, particularly because Walker's interviews straddle academic and popular presses. I am acknowledged for my contributions in the front matter of the edited volume.

COURSES TAUGHT AT VIRGINIA COMMONWEALTH UNIVERSITY:

MATX 604: Interdisciplinary Workshop, Spring 2018, Spring 2025

ENGL 382: African-American Literature: Realism to the Present, Fall 2015, Spring 2016, Fall 2016, Spring 2017, Fall 2017, Fall 2018, Fall 2019, Spring 2021, Fall 2023, Spring 2025

ENGL 499: Senior Seminar: Time Travel in the Literary Imagination, Fall 2020, Spring 2023, Spring 2024

ENGL 215: Reading Literature: Speculative Fiction, Fall 2016, Spring 2017, Fall 2018, Fall 2019, Spring 2020, Fall 2021, Spring 2023, Spring 2024

ENGL 301: Introduction to the English Major, Spring 2018, Spring 2020, Spring 2021, Fall 2023

MATX 690/ENGL 614/ENGL 499: Seminar in Media, Art, and Text/Cultural Discourses/Senior Seminar: Race and Recreation in the US, Fall 2022

ENGL 383: Short Fiction: Speculative Fiction Short Stories, Fall 2020, Fall 2021, Fall 2022

MATX 791: Directed Study on Literature and Protest with Nicholas Brown, Spring 2021

ENGL 499: Senior Seminar: Major Themes in Speculative Fiction, Fall 2017

ENGL 206: American Literature II: 1865-Present, Fall 2015, Spring 2016

ENGL 614: Cultural Discourses: Travel and African American Imagination, Spring 2015

ENGL 379/AFAM 379: African American Literature, Fall 2014, Spring 2015

ENGL 391/AMST 391/AFAM 491: Travel and African American Imagination, Fall 2014

DISSERTATION COMMITTEES:

Director, “Protest Literature and Black Digital Protest: Discourse on Race and Representation,” Nicholas Brown, MATX, 2026

Director, “The Fantasyscape Quotidian: On Life in Other Worlds,” Rian Johnson, MATX, 2025

Director, “Representation Matters! Minorities in Recreation and Implications for Media, Advertising and Sponsorships,” Latryce Noel, MATX, 2024

Member, “Teach Me How to Podcast: A Pedagogical Examination of Digital Audio Production Training across Disciplines,” Allison Bennett Dyche, MATX, 2023

Member, “Adaptive Acts: Queer Voices and Radical Adaptation in Multi-Ethnic American Literary and Visual Culture,” Michael Means, MATX, 2019

MASTER’S THESIS COMMITTEES:

Member, “Liner Notes on Black Trans Girlhood: Afrofuturist Affect, Self-Fashioning, & Black Popular Music,” Shawn Williams, Interdisciplinary Studies, May 2025

Member, “Archiving the Black Aesthetic: The Critical Power of Nonfiction in the Post Civil Rights Era,” Ariel Lawrence, English, 2018

Member, “‘It’s a Cu’ous Thing ter Me, Suh’: The Distinctive Narrative Innovation of Literary Dialect in Late-Nineteenth Century American Literature,” Kym Goering, English, 2016

SERVICE TO THE DEPARTMENT:

Member, Tenure and Promotion Peer Committee for Olivia Landry, Department of English, VCU, Fall 2026

Member, MATX Steering Committee, Department of English, VCU, Fall 2023- Spring 2025 and Fall 2026-Present

Member, MA Committee, Department of English, VCU, 2022-2025

Member, Executive Committee, Department of English, VCU, 2016-2017, 2018-2019, 2021-24

Member, Tenure and Promotion Peer Committee for Shermaine Jones, Department of English, VCU, Fall 2023

Member, Hiring Committee, Creative Nonfiction, Department of English, VCU, 2019-2020

Member, Hiring Committee, Creative Nonfiction, Department of English, VCU, 2016-2017

SERVICE TO THE COLLEGE/INSTITUTION:

Member, Tenure and Promotion Peer Committee for Grace Gipson, Department of African American Studies, VCU, Fall 2026

Member, Endowed Chair Review Committee, CHS, VCU, 2023-2025

Member, African American Male Initiative, CHS, VCU, 2017-2025

Member, LGBT+ and Queer Studies Steering Committee, CHS, VCU, 2019-2024

Member, GROWTH Award Task Force, CHS, VCU, Spring 2022

Faculty Council Representative (for Department of English), CHS, VCU, 2017-2020

SERVICE TO THE PROFESSION:

Member, Speculative Fiction Forum Executive Committee, MLA, 2024-Present

Manuscript reviewer (monograph), Columbia University Press, 2025

Manuscript reviewer (article), *Humanities*, 2022

Manuscript reviewer (articles), *African American Review* and *Journal of American Studies*, 2019

PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT:

Faculty Success Program, National Center for Faculty Diversity and Development, Spring 2020: Award funded by VCU Office of the Provost

VCU SafeZone (LGBTQIA+) Workshop, Fall 2016

PROFESSIONAL MEMBERSHIPS:

Popular Culture Association/American Culture Association

Modern Language Association